Beyond the Hype:

American fans' appreciations and reservations about Korean pop culture

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Introduction

- Growing attention and research on the Korean Wave but few empirical studies in the U.S.
- How is K-pop being received by diverse set of fans?
- What aspects of K-pop and Korean pop culture appeal to fans?
- What aspects do not?

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What does it say about fans' likes and dislikes?

- Yang (2012): cultural, racial, and social proximity
- Jung (2010): cultural discount, cultural odorlessness; Little K in K-pop (Lie 2012)
- Jung (2010): 'versatile masculinity,' 'soft masculinity'
- Lie (2015): pop perfectionism, cultural hybridity, talent pool, export oriented cultural industry
- Yoon (2018): Individuality and subculture identity; cultural affinity

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- We explore the landscape further with incomparably richer data.

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- about 1700 responses (970 American responses)
- online, fans' voluntary paticipation

Interview

- Over 100 interviews with diverse racial groups
- Asian, Korean, Black, Latine, and White
- Hand-coded interview text chunks

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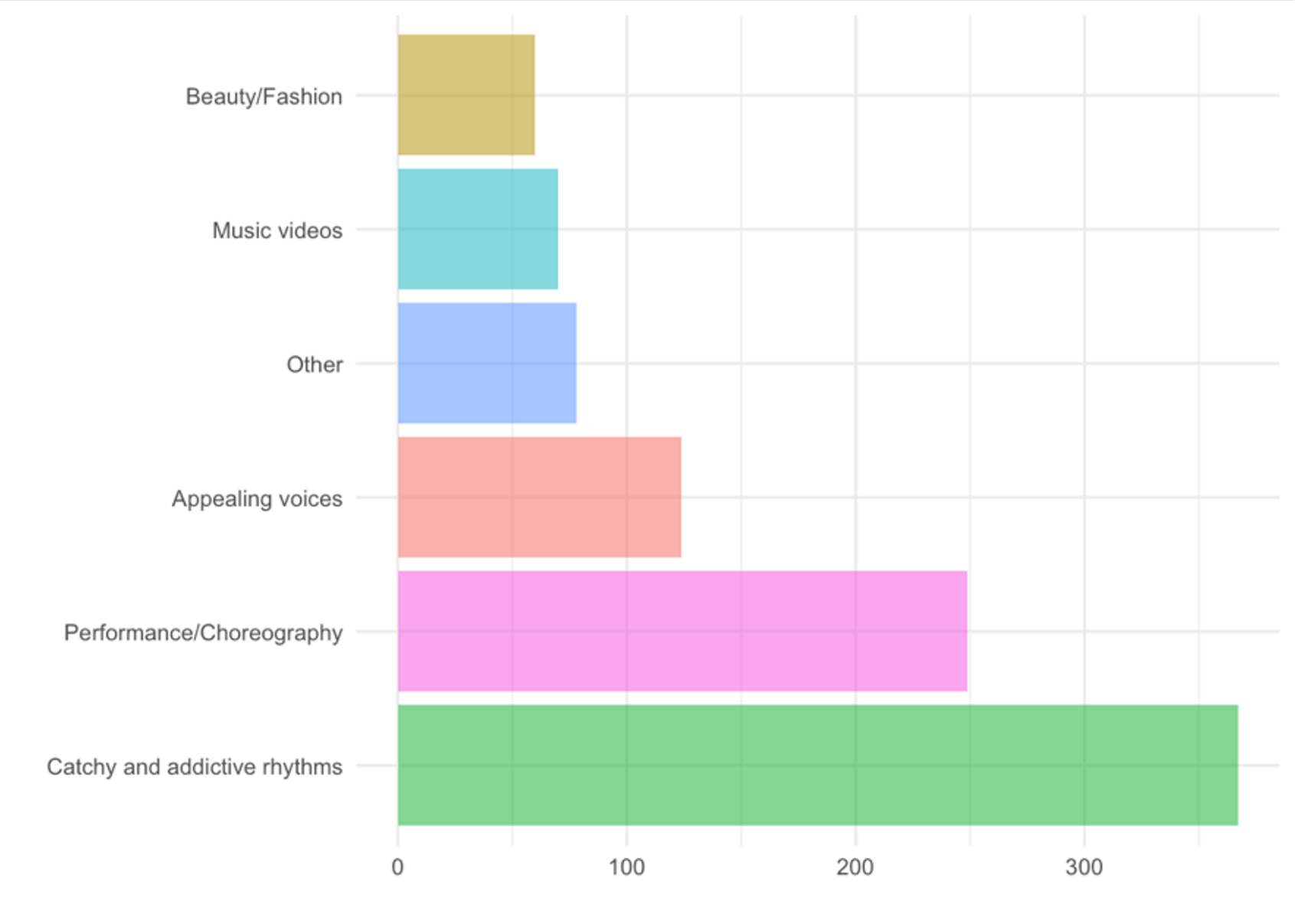
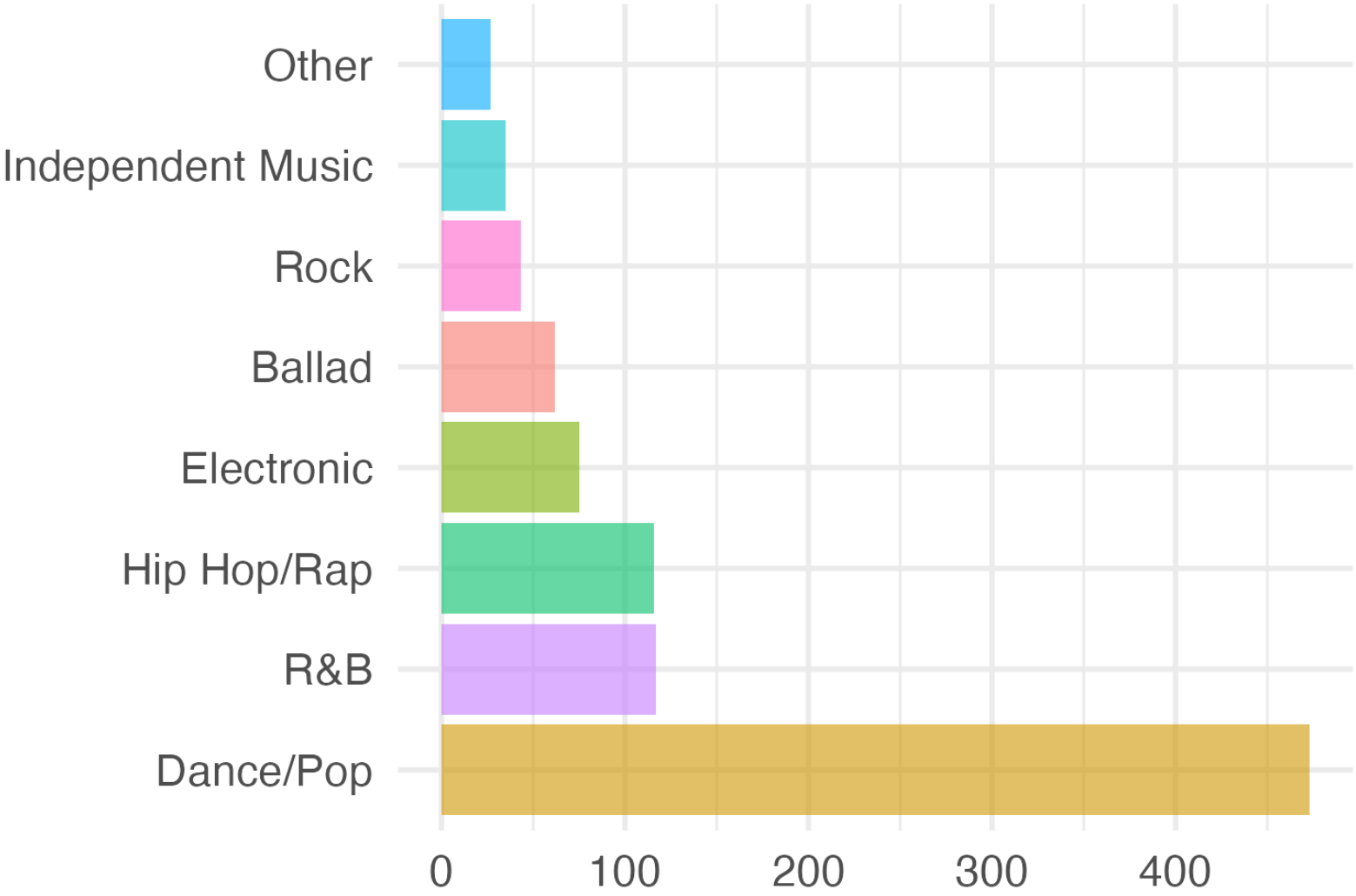
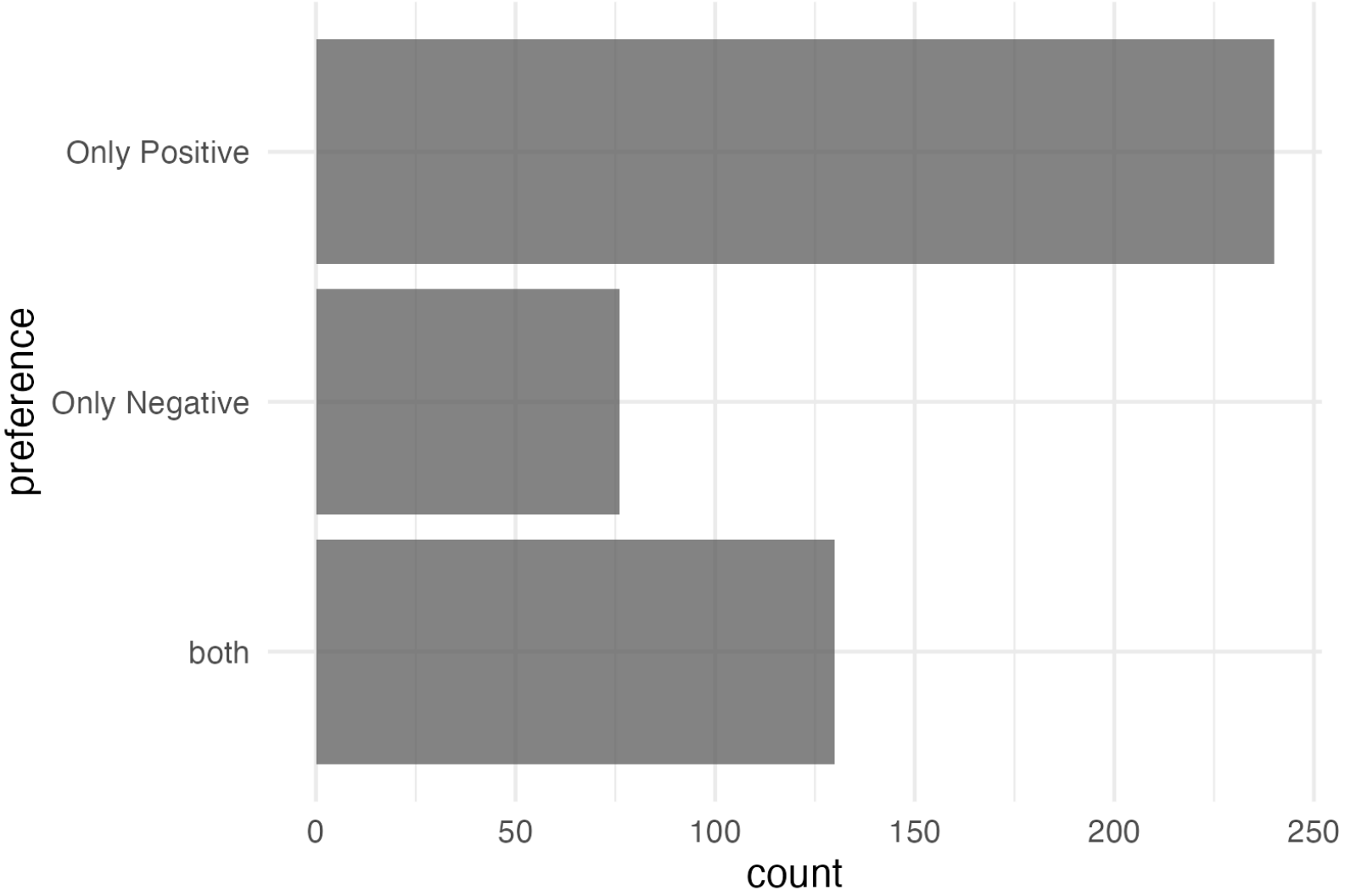
Online Survey (21-22): What do you like the most about K-pop?



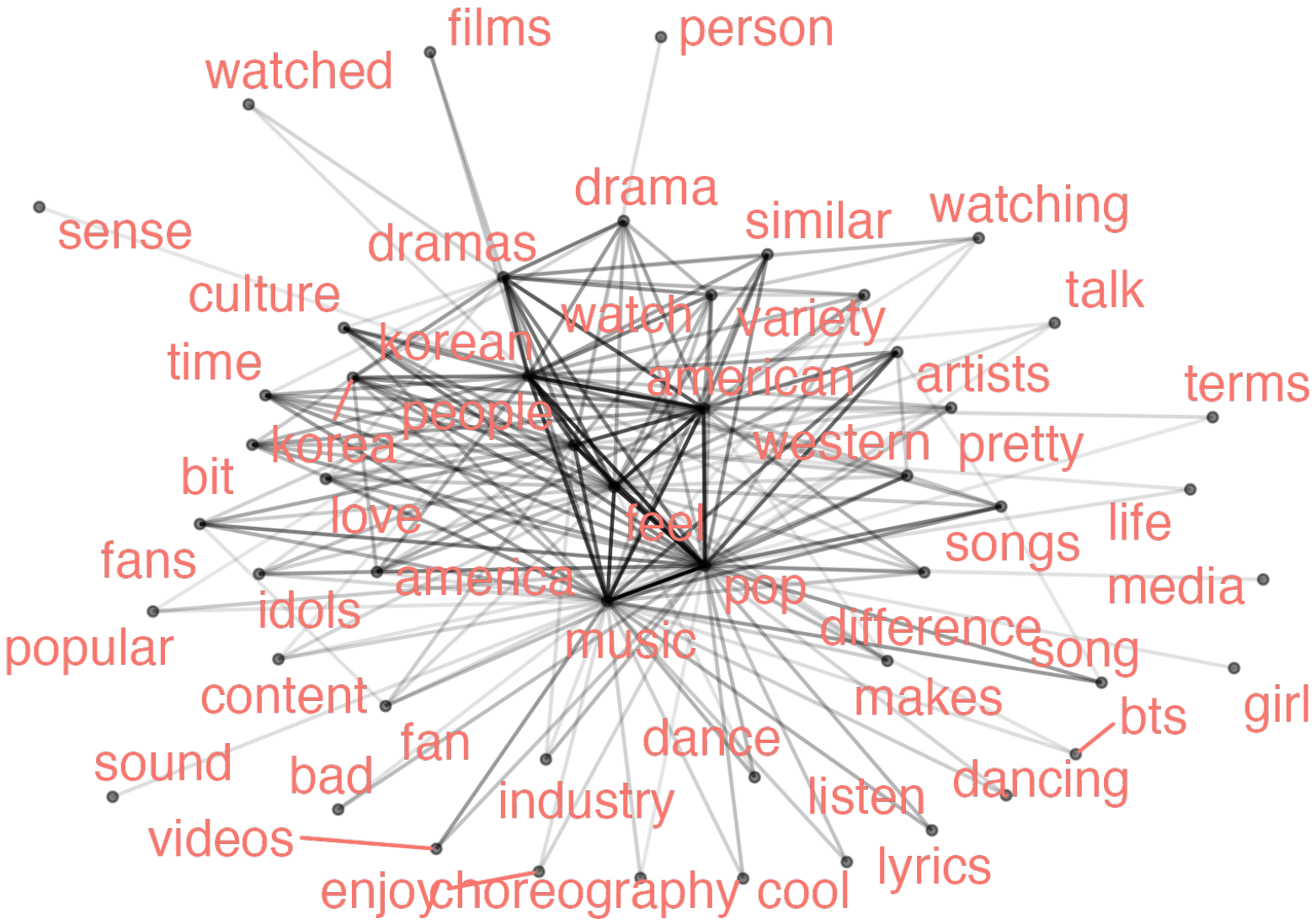
Online Survey (21-22): Favorite Genre



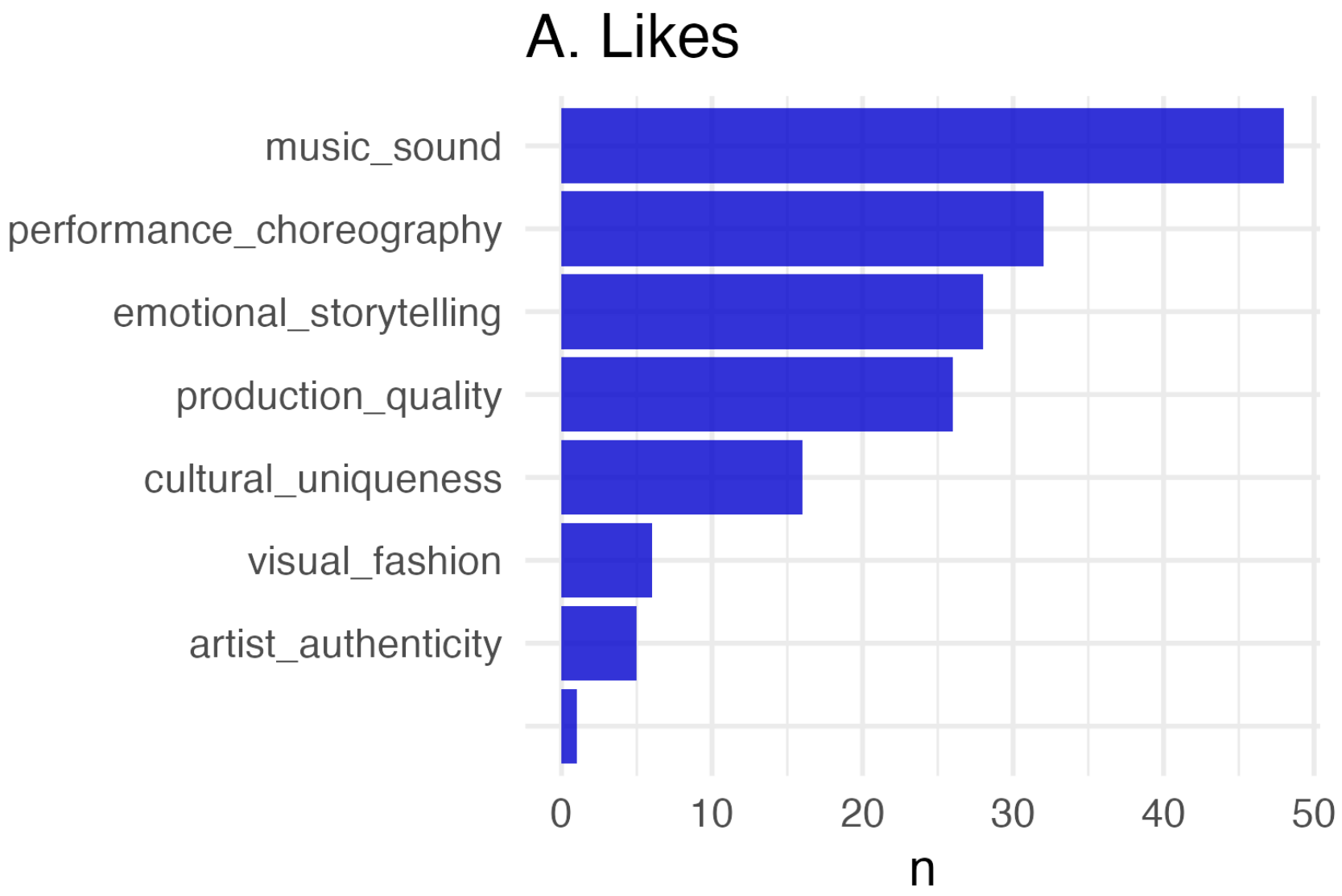
Interviews: 'Fan' doesn't mean they are always positive about K-pop.



Interviews: Overall Structure



Interviews: Things to Like & Dislike (aggregated to interviewee-level)



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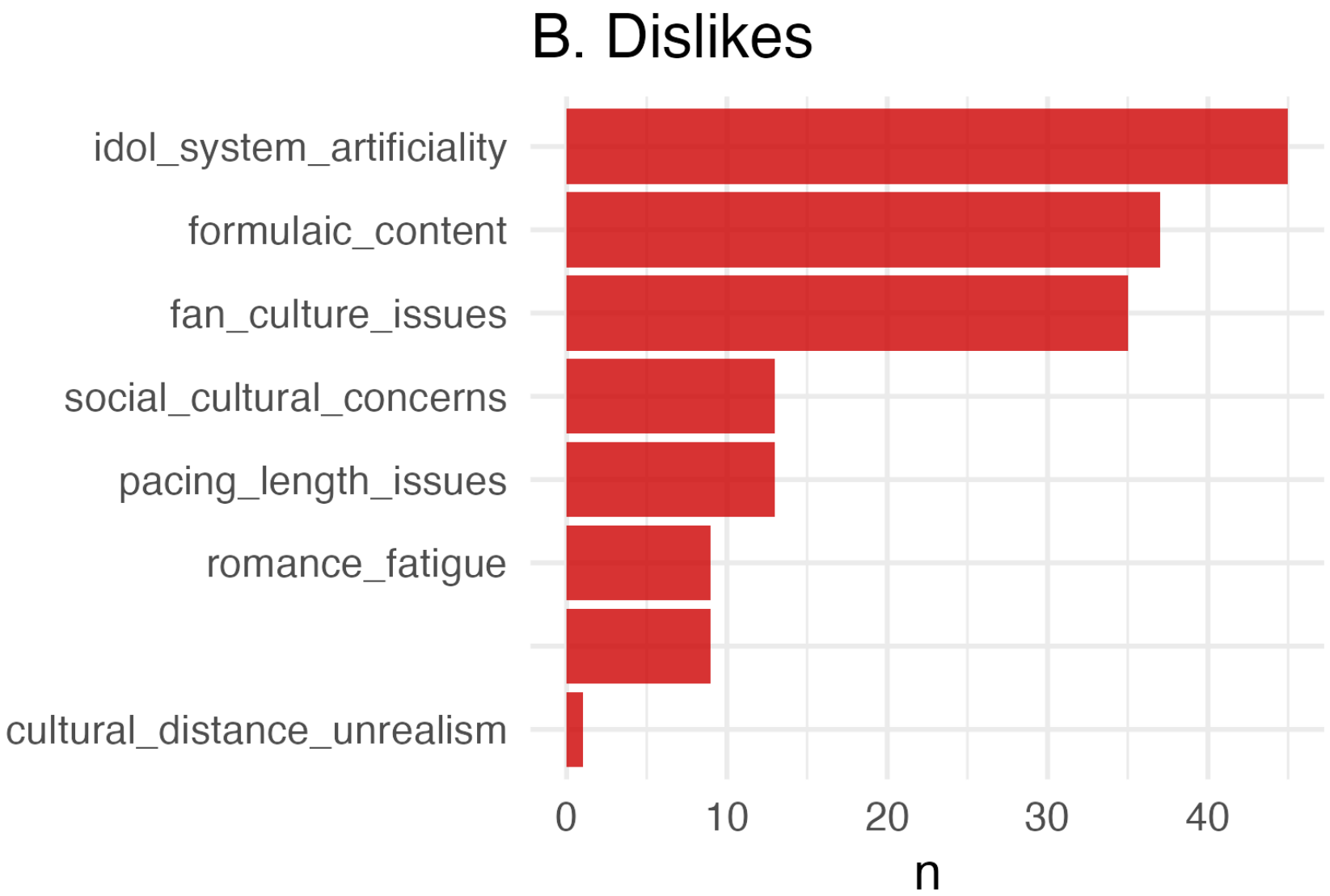
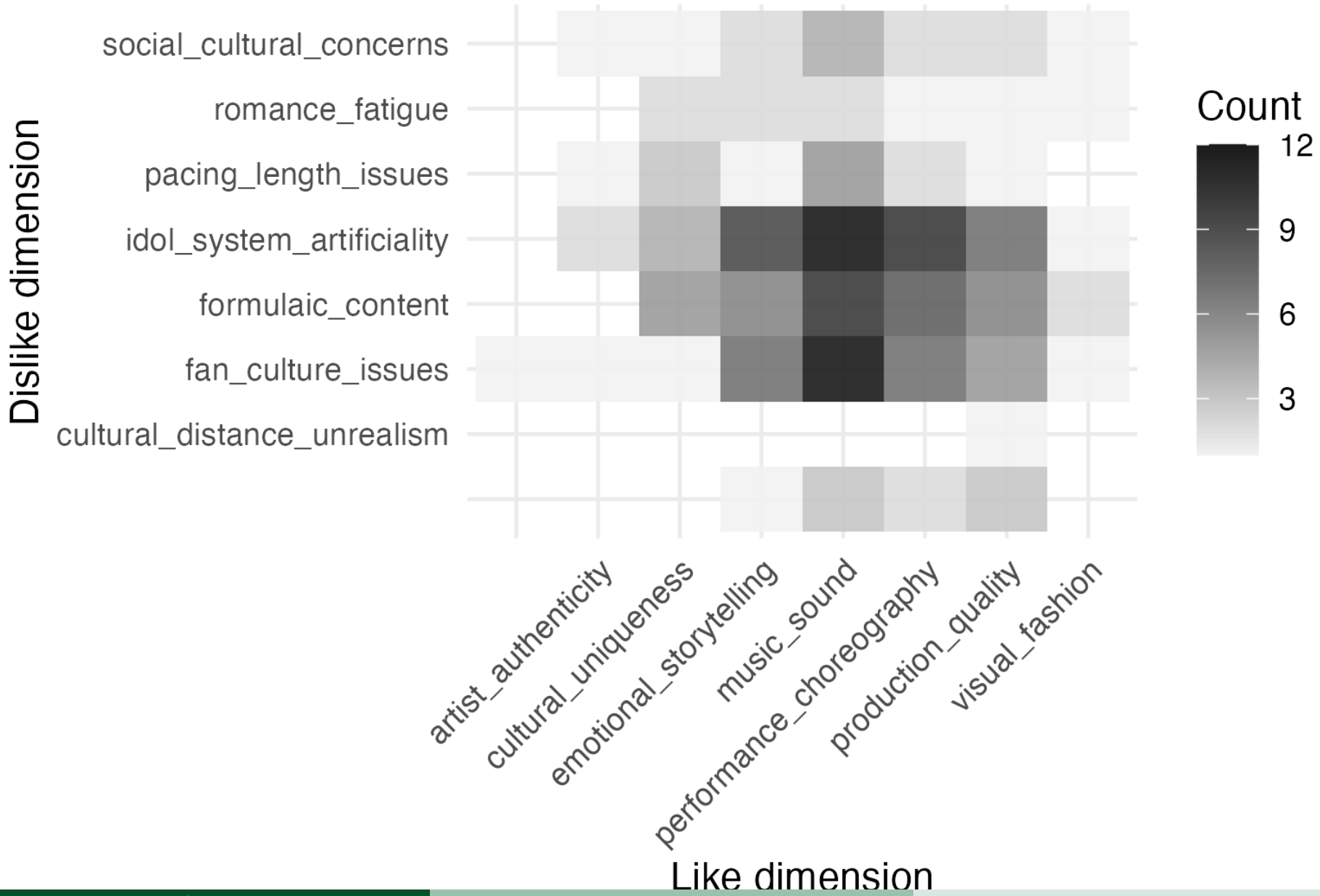


Interviews: The Relationship between Likes & Dislikes



Interviews: UPBEAT/CATCHY MUSIC; CHOREOGRAPHY; VISUALS; FAMILIAR BUT DISTINCTIVE SOUND; CONCEPTS

Black F, 20, Jamaica, 3/23/23 (Upbeat/catchy music): So, the music videos were definitely the biggest initial draw for me because it was so high quality and definitely not as boring as a lot of Western music videos at the time. So, I think that was the biggest draw for me. The songs just sound really good. They're dancing. So, that's I think the dancing makes it more entertaining to watch as well. So, like, just upon like initially like it, that's, there's that and then I also enjoy a lot of the shows.

White F, 19, 11/20/22 (production quality, concepts, visuals): K-pop videos are really fun to watch or like music videos, because they're just, they, there's different levels of production that you're not seeing. And it's like all these concepts and such, but I really liked it. I think that's, it's really cool. And I like that K-pop also often has, the groups have concepts that they fit for each different debut. I think that's really fun and also just fashion for both K-drama, films, and K-pop. I think fashion is what I like about it as well.

Interviews: Fan service; Idol-fan interactions

White F, 19, 11/20/22: And like, I think Korean artists really kind of cater to that effect and like, really cater to their fans and make them seem like they're the number one thing in their, in their world as if [inaudible] their occupation. And so I think the everyday K-pop fan is a bit delusional just because for [inaudible] that you think you're in touch more with, with this, you know, this artists.

White M, 21, 12/5/19: Cause I feel like a lot of them, that's one of the things about the VLive and stuff like that is like it gives them a more personal feel. Like you're able to connect with the artists and whatever. A little bit more. It's kind of like be with them one on one. I feel like a lot of American artists don't really do that as much. Like they'll go on my stuff like reality shows or whatever.

Interviews: K-POP PERFECTIONISM; AMOUNT OF CONTENT; SOCIAL AND DIGITAL MEDIA PLATFORMS; GROUP DYNAMICS

Latinx F, 20, 12/29/20 (K-pop perfectionism, amount of content): They're like really funny. (I: Going Seventeen) Yes, yes, yes, I love going Seventeen. They're funny and then they like they can sing really well and they can dance really well, I really, I really appreciate their dancing cuz like, they're all like synchronized and stuff. But they also like put out a lot of content like for their fans. So it's not like, it's like three YouTube videos like a week or something. And then they're, like, really active on like, social media. So it's nice to like, you can feel really connected to them.

Asian F, 21, FilipinE, 10/10/22 (group dynamic): "I think what first got me into K-pop is like, the whole concept thing behind the groups, right? It just makes it really fun to follow because I think people like stories. And especially since there's groups there's the whole culture, at least for K-pop with like, "who's your bias "? And then you can, you can kind of like, again, you can like personalize the group for yourself.

Interviews: SENSE OF COMMUNITY; FRIENDSHIPS; SHARED INTERESTS; VALIDATION; INSPIRATIONAL; ENTERTAINMENT; ESCAPISM

Asian F, 19, Vietnam, 12/2/22: Yeah, like, I feel like it's really, there's nothing more like supportive than like, all of these people that I don't know just coming together to support a group that like we all genuinely really like. I think there's just nothing like it.

White F, 29, 4/2/21: Oh man, the community is one thing for me because I have made so many friends with other fans. And that's huge for me and I've gotten closer to people I was already friends with once we both got into the [group].

Latine M, 20, Mixed, 7/30/20: Like Yoon-gi his story really like touched me a lot because I kind of like go through the same stuff for some of the same stuff and like to see like where he is now. It gives me hope that I can be like successful in way that I can only dream of now.

Black F, 21, Ethiopia, 2/28/20: I think it's just, it's, it's mindless, like you can just say and just watch it, just laugh with or entertaining.

Interviews: FORMULAIC; COPYCAT/HERD MENTALITY; LACK CREATIVITY; COMMERCIAL; MANUFACTURED

Black F, 23, Latinx, 8/8/20 (formulaic): Um, so a lot of I guess when I first got into K-pop, it was interesting, but then the more I listened to it, the different songs in different bands, the more some of the songs sounded the same to me. Like the beats, the rhythms. Even if the lyrics were different, and all of this sounded the same.

Asian F, 18, China, 12/1/22 (commercial)" "as it's developing now, it's kind of like it became, it becomes more mechanical. Like all the companies like they're trying to just use, utilize their artists to just earn money and they are not like trying to promote the real meaningful thing to people, but they're just trying to think how can they sell more albums."

Interviews: Cultural appropriation and anti-Black attitudes

Black American, F, 59, 10/2/22

The only thing I would just say I dislike is whenever they use certain styles of dress that are just so obviously originated from Black people in hip hop in the 80s and 90s, which I know pretty well since you know I was a young person back then. And you know, I hear that they say, you know, just very negative things about specifically Black, African American people. That's really, really disheartening when they obviously have taken so much of the style and made it their own.

Interviews: OVERZEALOUS FANS; FAN HATE/CRITICISM; IDOL MENTAL HEALTH; FAN WARS; MULTI-FANS

Asian F, 21, Indian, 10/11/22: Yeah, like, they're kind of evil sometimes. Like, they just be bullying each other. It's, like, they actually...your groups, like, don't hate each other... Like, they're kind of friends. So, it's weird for you to be bullying each other, like, online. It's, like, roasting the hell out of one another and, like, going to war or, like, cyber bullying or, like, leaking people's photos. That's messed up.

Latine F, 20, 12/29/20: I think sometimes, like within the fans, if they like, really like one group, then there'll be like, 'Oh, this is the best group and no other group is going to be better than this group.' I don't know why. Um, but I think that like that part of K-pop can be like, kind of like, mean and stuff because they like to talk bad about other groups.

Latine M, 20, Mixed, 7/30/20: And I've seen this a lot within like the fandoms that I'm a part of. It is really hard being a multi, multifan because you want to stand up for this group, but then you also want to defend this one, and people that aren't into multiple groups don't really understand.

Interviews: BEAUTY STANDARDS; PLASTIC SURGERY; SELF ESTEEM ISSUES; colorism

Asian, F, 20, Korean, 11/19/22: I guess the bad side of it all is like, the beauty standards. It's kind of like there's a lot to it and there's a lot, I don't know because I think personally, I've been negatively impacted in terms of my own body image just from consumption of Korean pop culture"

Asian F, 29, Bangladesh, 6/28/21: I also don't like the beauty standards. Like how you have to be a certain way, how you have to look a certain way, like how you have to, or like, even like skin tone, like skin color, skin color stuff, like, you know, like, you know, if you're more pale, you're like you're more beautiful, if you're darker, but it's like, it's like that in my culture too.

Conclusion

- Selectiveness of the sample → prior interest in anime and East Asia, high parental education, open-mindedness, and cosmopolitan outlook.
- Music-related factors feature prominently as the reasons for 'likes'.
- Industry-related factors important in the reasons for 'dislikes'.
- Some ambivalence in the 'quality': likes high quality but dislikes manufacturedness
- Non-music/performance related factors (social/cultural) are not raised as frequently.

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